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ENVS 40, Wednesday 10AM section

Project Overview:

For this project, I plan to create a lesson plan for elementary school students about tide pools. This will include an overview of the ecosystem, information on common species found in tide pools, and instruction on how to explore them in a way that is safe for both the students themselves and the creatures and ecosystems they are observing. The question I will be answering is: What is the significance of tide pools, and what are the best ways for young students to explore them?

I plan to accomplish this by tackling each part of the research separately, and combining it to make a cohesive class for hypothetical students. I will begin by researching how to make a successful lesson plan. I will then research each topic I plan to include, and from there, I will condense and simplify the information to make it understandable for kids. Throughout this project, I hope to learn techniques to make engaging and informative lesson plans, and gain a deeper knowledge about tidepools and their marine species, specifically in the region of the central/southern California coast.

Critical Thinking:

This project will make me think critically about the environment because, first and foremost, I will be researching tidepools, which are an extremely important and unique marine ecosystem. Since this project combines information from many disciplines (education, marine biology, and many others), it will require critical thinking while researching and while finding the best way to combine the many elements involved. It will also require a deeper understanding than just surface level research because I cannot just paraphrase from a paper or article. It will require me to break everything down into facts that are digestible for young students

Guiding Questions:

What are tide pools and why are they important? How can I make sure the lesson is engaging and informative? What lessons do I want these hypothetical students to walk away with?

Significance:

This project involves critical thinking because it requires thinking about how to help someone else understand something. This is particularly difficult since my project specifically is about teaching young kids. This requires an in-depth understanding, especially since young students ask lots and lots of questions. My project is significant because it has the potential to give students hands-on learning experiences and lessons that they may carry with them for a long time. Learning about and developing an appreciation for the ocean is critical for a generation that

is being raised in the climate crisis. Instilling the importance of the environment at a young age will lead to kids that care about their planet and want to protect and restore it.

Steps:

I plan to accomplish this project by researching each subtopic separately. I will start with researching the best way to make a lesson plan for elementary school students. With this information, I will make an outline for the lesson plan to know what specific information would be most important to cover. Next, I plan to research tidepools and their characteristics as an ecosystem. From there, I will boil down the most important information to make it digestible for the class. I will focus the beginning of the lesson on this subject. Next, I will compile a guide to common species in tide pools on the central to southern coast of California. This will be explained and given to the students so they can know what to look for. The guide will include photos, general information such as size and how common or rare they are in various areas, and fun facts about each creature. From there, I will explain how to explore tide pools safely. This safety applies to both the students and the ecosystem they will be enjoying. These lessons will include things like not turning their backs on the ocean and watching for slippery rocks and algae, as well as making sure they understand not to take anything from the pools or disrupt the environment.

Guidance for TA feedback:

I am hoping for any kind of feedback I can get. It would be helpful to know if this is a good idea as a whole, since I have been a little bit stuck on the very general prompt. I think that it is specific enough, but I am a little unsure on what the best way would be to present it. I would also appreciate guidance on types of evidence I should include. Any advice would be extremely welcome because I am a little unclear of the overall expectation for this project.